

Using the PATHFINDER Composer

A guide for coordinators submitting news and events

The Composer is a form on the PATHFINDER website that lets you write a news item or an event and download it as a ready-to-publish file — **without touching GitHub, YAML, or code.**

URL: `https://<your-live-url>/admin/compose`

The page is unlisted (not in the site's menu, hidden from search engines). Bookmark the URL when your maintainer sends it to you.

What the Composer does — and doesn't

-  Takes what you type and formats it correctly for the website.
-  Shows a live preview so you can see how the news card and article will look.
-  Generates the right filename and downloads the file for you.
-  Does **not** publish anything on its own. You still need to send the downloaded file to your publisher.

Think of it as a "clean the format for me" tool. Publishing is a separate step handled by the designated publisher (contact your project coordinator to know who that is).

Writing a news item

1. Go to `/admin/compose`.
2. Confirm the toggle at the top says **News item** (the darker button). If not, click it.
3. Fill in the fields:
 - **Title** — a short, punchy headline (max 120 characters).
 - **Date** — the date of publication. Defaults to today.
 - **Summary** — one or two sentences that will show on the News card. This is what people see before clicking through.
 - **Body** — the full article. Uses Markdown for formatting (see below).
 - **Tags (optional)** — one or two labels, comma-separated (e.g. `event-recap, sarajevo`).
 - **Author (optional)** — your name or the name of whoever wrote the piece.
4. **(Optional)** Click **Add an image** to include a hero photo. See [managing-images.md](#) for what to put here.

5. Watch the **Preview** on the right — the news card and article both update as you type.
6. When you're happy, click **Download .md**. A file like `2027-05-15-my-title.md` saves to your Downloads folder.
7. Send that file to the publisher (see the "Sending to the publisher" section below).

Writing an event

Same flow as news, but click the **Event** toggle at the top first. The form changes:

- **Title** — the event's name (e.g. "Sofia Forum on AI and the Future of Work").
- **Start date** and **End date (optional)** — the date(s) the event runs.
- **Location** — city and country (e.g. "Sofia, Bulgaria" or "Online").
- **Country** — pick from the dropdown. "Online" is a valid choice for virtual events.
- **Format** — In-person / Online / Hybrid.
- **Summary** — a one- or two-sentence description shown on the events grid.
- **Body** — full agenda, background, or details in Markdown.
- **Registration URL (optional)** — a link where people can register.

Everything else works the same. Download, send to publisher.

Formatting the body

There are two ways to format text in the **Body** field:

1. Toolbar buttons (easiest)

Right above the body textarea there's a small toolbar:

- **B** — bold. Select some text and click B, or click B and start typing.
-  **Link** — insert a link. Select the text you want linked, click Link, then type or paste the URL in the popup.
- **H2** — turn the current line into a section heading.
- **H3** — turn the current line into a sub-heading.
- **• List** — turn the current line (or selected lines) into a bulleted list.
- **“ Quote** — turn the current line into a quote block.

The preview on the right updates immediately so you see exactly what will render.

2. Type Markdown directly

The toolbar is just a shortcut — you can type the same syntax by hand. That's plain text with a few simple rules:

```
## A section heading
### A smaller heading

A paragraph. Just type normally.

Leave a blank line between paragraphs.

**Bold** and *italic*.

- A bulleted list
- Another item

1. A numbered list
2. Another item

[A link to somewhere](https://example.org)

> A quote or callout.
```

The preview shows exactly how it will render. If it looks right in the preview, it will look right on the live site.

Sending to the publisher

The publisher for PATHFINDER content receives files at:

`info@the-pathfinder-project.eu` (confirm with your coordinator — this may change)

To send:

1. Open a new email to the publisher.
2. Subject line: something like "News item: Sarajevo recap" or "Event: Sofia Forum".
3. Attach the `.md` file you downloaded.
4. Optionally include a note if there's context or a suggested publish time.
5. Send.

The publisher will upload the file to GitHub, at which point the site will update within about a minute.

FAQs

"Can I edit an already-published post?" — The composer only creates new files. To edit an existing news item or event, ask the publisher (they can do it directly on GitHub) or see [editing-directly.md](#) if you're comfortable with the web editor.

"What if I don't upload an image?" — Then the PATHFINDER logo appears on the card and article. Perfectly fine as a default.

"What if I want to save my work and come back later?" — Click Download. Keep the `.md` file on your computer. Later, open it in any text editor, edit, and re-attach when you're ready.

"Is my content saved anywhere while I'm typing?" — No. If you close the tab before downloading, your work is lost. Download before you close.

"Can I preview my post on the live site before it publishes?" — Only if your publisher opens a Pull Request (draft mode) instead of committing directly. Ask them to do that if you want a private preview URL before it goes live.

"Someone else already saw the composer URL. Is that a security problem?" — No. The composer generates text; it can't publish anything. Only committed changes on GitHub reach the site, and only your maintainer can commit. See [troubleshooting.md](#) for more on this.

If something in the composer doesn't work as expected, check [troubleshooting.md](#) or contact the technical maintainer.